INDIA'S LITHIUM MOMENT

The country's grand EV ambitions get a leg-up with the prospect of a 5.9 million tonne lithium reserve in Jammu and Kashmir's Reasi district

By Moazum Mohammad in Reasi



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Not much stirs in the sleepy hilltop village of Salal in the Reasi district of Jammu and Kashmir. It does offer a commanding view of the serpentine Chenab river, alongside sparkling snow-capped mountains and green hills. The district is also home to two of India's engineering marvels—the 690MW Salal hydropower project and the world's highest rail bridge. The 1,315-metre-long arch bridge is 359 metres above the Chenab river bed. That is 35 metres higher than the Eiffel Tower in Paris.

But no one imagined that—apart from offering construction material—the rocky terrain here would put Salal at the centre of the global market for lithium. The soft, silvery-white alkali metal is used in a range of key components of rechargeable batteries, solar panels, mobile phones, laptops and even psychiatric drugs.

Last month, after the 62nd meeting of the apex Central Geological Programming Board, the Union ministry of mines announced, among other things, that Salal—77 km away from Jammu city—has substantial lithium deposits for exploration. The initial estimate suggests a staggering potential of 5.9 million tonnes (MT) of 'inferred' resources of the metal, a figure that sent many—from the government, the industry and the village—into an ecstatic whirl. The final deposit amount could be less than predicted but the preliminary findings by the Geological Survey of India (GSI) suggest that India may be home to the sixth largest reserves of lithium in the world, ahead of China's known reserves of 5.1 MT. If the GSI's findings bear out, this could kickstart India's electric vehicles (EV) revolution.

Known as 'white gold' for its scarcity and high price, lithium is widely used in batteries due to its high electrochemical potential and low weight. Data tabled in Parliament shows India imported lithium worth Rs 522 crore in the three years beginning in 2019. Similarly, lithium-ion (Li-ion) cells, a dominant component in batteries used in electric vehicles, worth Rs 26,204 crore were imported. This comes in the face of the central government's push for greener mobility amid a slew of measures like the exemption of customs duty for the production of Li-ion cells.

India is already witnessing a